but the common punishment of the knoot is often dreaded more than death, and sometimes a criminal has endeavoured to bribe the executioner to kill him. This punishment seldom causes immediate death, but death is often the consequence of it.

PETERSBURG. The governor of the police at Petersburg was so kind as to fix a time for showing me all the instruments commonly used for punishment—the axe and block—the machine (now out of use) for breaking the arms and legs—the instrument for slitting or lacerating the nostrils—and that for marking criminals (which is done by punctuation, and then rubbing a black powder on the wounds)—the knoot whip—and another called the cat, which consists of a number of thongs from two to ten. The knoot whip is fixed to a wooden handle a foot long, and consists of several thongs about two feet in length twisted together, to the end of which is fastened a single tough thong of a foot and a half, tapering towards a point, and capable of being changed by the executioner, when too much softened by the blood of the criminal.

10 August, 1781, I saw two criminals, a man and a woman, suffer the punishment of the knoot. They were conducted from prison by about fifteen hussars and ten soldiers. When they arrived at the place of punishment, the hussars formed themselves into a ring round the whipping-post, the drum beat a minute or two, and then some prayers were repeated, the populace taking off their hats. The woman was taken first; and after being roughly stripped to the waist, her hands and feet were bound with cords to a post made for the purpose, a man standing before the post to keep the cords tight. A servant attended the executioner, and both were stout men. The servant first marked his ground, and struck the woman five times on the back. Every stroke seemed to penetrate deep into her flesh. But his master thinking him too gentle, pushed him aside, took his place, and gave all the remaining strokes himself, which were evidently more severe. The woman received twenty-five, and the man sixty: I pressed through the hussars, and counted the number as they were chalked on a board. Both seemed but just alive, especially the man, who yet had strength enough to receive a small donation with some signs of gratitude. They were conducted back to prison in a little wagon. I saw the woman in a very weak condition some days after, but could not find the man any more.

In the fortress there are many vaulted rooms, some of which are now used for the confinement of deserters, and criminals

of various sorts, who work on the fortifications. Some were glad of the privilege of being employed in the governor's garden, for the sake of the flour which he gave them for their labour. Others, with logs to their legs, were drawing wood out of the Neva. Thirty-five were crowded into one of the rooms, which therefore was excessively hot, having only two small apertures (ten inches by nine) for the admission of air. In another part of this building, seventy-five slaves with logs fastened to both their legs, were lodged in four rooms, which were still more close and offensive. In a few rooms (used as barracks) some officers were confined. Every room was furnished with an oven or stove, and most of them with barrack-beds.

In the police prison there were in one room nine women, and in two other rooms forty-four men. In two small and low arched cellars (very hot and offensive) I saw fifteen men, most of them in irons. In a room called the infirmary, detached from the rest of the prison, there were seven persons sick. All the prisoners subsist on voluntary contributions, collected in boxes before their grates, and at church. This is all the advantage they derive from the church near the prison, for they are never permitted to enter it, or to go out of their rooms; except on particular occasions with guards of soldiers.

The prison for debtors consists of four vaulted rooms communicating with one another, and furnished with stoves and barrack-beds. The prisoners are never permitted to go out of their rooms. They subsist by alms received from passengers in little boxes placed before the windows; but government supplies them with wood for fuel. One told me, he had been confined for five years, for a debt of fifteen roubles; and another, four years for twenty-five roubles.

On a rising ground at a little distance from Petersburg, and on the south side of the river Neva, there is a stately pile of buildings, originally designed for a convent, but ever since 1764 converted by the Empress Catherine the Second, into a public establishment for educating the female nobility of Russia, and a limited number of the children of commoners. The sleeping rooms and dining-halls in these buildings are remarkably lofty and airy, having large galleries round them; and adjoining to the buildings there are spacious gardens and lawns, which extend to the banks of the river. The number of the children of nobility on this establishment is two hundred; and the number of the children of commoners, or peasants was, till 1770, limited to two hundred and forty: but since this year it has been